

THE GIRL FROM JUNAGADH

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Achievements



1. Broke into the Junior Top 50 rankings on September 14, 2026.
2. Reached the semifinals of a W15 tournament in Delhi in April, only her second event on the senior circuit. In the process, she broke Sania Mirza's record of being the youngest Indian woman to reach the quarterfinals and semifinals of a senior professional tournament.
3. First Indian girl to win the Australian Open Asia-Pacific Elite Under-14 Trophy.
4. Titles — J200 (Astana, 2026), J60 (Guwahati, 2025), J30 (Ahmedabad, 2025).

Dipakbhai Kanabar wanted his daughter to play like Steffi Graf. Today, Jensi is writing her **own chapter.**

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Watching Steffi Graf play at Wimbledon in the early 1990s left such an impression on Imran Mirza that he wondered whether his young daughter should take up the sport. He acted on it, setting in motion the illustrious career of Sania Mirza, the greatest female player India has produced so far.

Whether Graf has done it again will be known in the years to come, but the rapid progress of Jensi Kanabar suggests that perhaps a sequel is in the making. On September 14, the 14-year-old made her debut in the Top 50 of the ITF Junior Rankings.

Dipakbhai Kanabar, Jensi's father, was a big fan of Graf and, when he was blessed with a daughter in 2011, there was no doubt in his mind. "I used to follow tennis with a keen interest. She was my favourite player and I wanted Jensi to be a player like her," he tells *Sportstar*.

Accordingly, Dipakbhai (**left, with Jensi**), a schoolteacher by profession, started sending three-and-a-half-year-old Jensi for tennis coaching at the local gymkhana in Junagadh, a city in western Gujarat with a population of roughly five lakh.

But unlike Graf, the player Dipakbhai idolised, Jensi is left-handed. How did that happen?

Dipakbhai describes it as "a blunder".

"When I sent Jensi to train for the first time under Somnath bhai, who himself was 16-17 years old at the time, he asked her to throw a ball. When she threw it with her left hand, the ball went further. So, he assumed it was Jensi's stronger hand. I wasn't even aware of this until Jensi had completed a year of training."

When he found out, Dipakbhai did ask around whether she should switch to the right hand, but he was advised against it.

In 2019, when she was eight and had participated in a few local competitions, Jensi played her first national-level tournament — an U12 AITA event in Rajkot.

But soon, the COVID-19 pandemic hit the world, bringing an end to tournaments and leaving Jensi with just training at the gymkhana.

That period prompted Dipakbhai to take a major step in shaping his daughter's career. "I realised that she could not get high-level coaching at the gymkhana anymore," he recalls.

So, he and three friends, who also had young children playing